CHAPTER 9

# CHANGE AND DEVELOPMENT IN RURAL SOCIETY

**CHAPTER ESSENCE AT A GLANCE:**
Analyze rural transformation in India through agrarian class structure, colonial land revenue legacies, post-independence land reforms, the technological and socio-ecological impacts of the Green Revolution, footloose migrant labour, and contemporary agrarian distress.

## 4 CORE PRINCIPLES TO UNDERSTAND FIRST

• **Agrarian Class Stratification and Land Relations:** Rural society is structured by unequal access to land; the agrarian hierarchy comprises absentee landlords, rich capitalist peasants, small and marginal owner-cultivators, tenants, and landless agricultural labourers, tightly correlated with caste rank.

• **Land Reforms: Ambitions and Compromises:** Post-independence land reforms sought to dismantle feudal landlordism through abolition of zamindari intermediaries, tenancy security regulations, and land ceiling acts; while successful in Kerala and West Bengal through political mobilization, ceilings were largely evaded elsewhere via benami transfers.

• **Green Revolution Dynamics and Inequalities:** The Green Revolution introduced High-Yielding Variety (HYV) seeds, chemical inputs, and tubewell irrigation in fertile tracts (Punjab, Haryana, Western UP); it achieved national food self-sufficiency but exacerbated regional disparities, marginalized smallholders, and triggered environmental degradation.

• **Agrarian Distress and Labour Transformations:** Commercialization led to the casualization of farm labour and footloose migration (Jan Breman); spiraling input costs, volatile global market prices, and predatory non-institutional credit generated severe agrarian distress, manifested in catastrophic farmers' suicides.

## ESSENTIAL SOCIOLOGICAL CONCEPTS & INSTITUTIONS

$$\text{Agrarian Class Hierarchy} \rightarrow \text{Landlords} \rightarrow \text{Rich Capitalist Farmers} \rightarrow \text{Marginal Peasants} \rightarrow \text{Landless Labourers}$$
*Four-Tier Subcontinental Agrarian Stratification*

$$\text{Green Revolution Technology Package} \Longleftrightarrow \text{HYV Seeds} + \text{Chemical Fertilizers} + \text{Assured Irrigation} + \text{Pesticides}$$
*Techno-Agronomic Quadriad of Intensive Agriculture*

$$\text{Green Revolution Consequences} \rightarrow \{\text{Productive: Food Self-Sufficiency}, \quad \text{Distributive: Regional Imbalance and Peasant Dispossession}\}$$
*Socioeconomic Duality of Technocratic Farming*

$$\text{Agrarian Distress Matrix} \Longleftrightarrow \text{High Cost of Commercial Inputs} + \text{Crop Failure} + \text{Informal Usury} \rightarrow \text{Farmer Debt Trap}$$
*Structural Drivers of Contemporary Rural Distress*

## CRUCIAL EXAM PRECAUTIONS & VALUATION RUBRIC SECRETS

• **Alert:** The Green Revolution was initially implemented only in regions with assured irrigation and wealthy farmers; it bypassed rain-fed drylands and eastern India, widening inter-regional economic inequality.

• **Alert:** Land ceiling acts were largely circumvented in most Indian states because large landlords utilized loopholes to register excess lands under fake names or relatives (benami transfers).

• **Alert:** Jan Breman coined the term 'footloose labour' to characterize landless migrant workers who circulate continually between impoverished villages and seasonal rural or urban work sites without labour protections.

## HIGH-YIELD CENTUM QUESTIONS & STEP-BY-STEP EXPLANATIONS

**1. Define the agrarian structure and mention its core determinant in rural India. [Score: 2 Marks]**

**Answer & Key Valuation Steps:**

• **Definition:** Agrarian structure refers to the structure of landholding, land tenure relationships, and the distribution of agricultural assets and classes in rural society. **[1 Mark]**

• **Core Determinant:** Access to arable land is the primary determinant of agrarian social structure, governing economic power, political dominance, and social status. **[1 Mark]**

**2. What were the two major land tenure systems introduced by the British in India, and how did they affect peasant livelihoods? [Score: 3 Marks]**

**Answer & Key Valuation Steps:**

• **Zamindari System:** Implemented in Bengal and parts of North India; recognized feudal landlords as absolute owners of land, turning actual cultivators into insecure, rack-rented tenants subject to heavy exploitation. **[1.5 Marks]**

• **Ryotwari System:** Implemented in Madras and Bombay Presidencies; settled land revenue directly with individual cultivators (ryots), but fixed exorbitant revenue demands that drove peasants into the hands of moneylenders. **[1.5 Marks]**

**3. Discuss the key components of post-independence land reforms in India. Why were land ceiling acts mostly ineffective outside a few states? [Score: 4 Marks]**

**Answer & Key Valuation Steps:**

• **Key Components:** Abolition of feudal zamindari intermediaries, granting security of tenure to actual tillers, and imposition of land ceiling acts on maximum land ownership. **[1.5 Marks]**

• **Success in Specific States:** Tenancy reforms were exceptionally successful in Kerala and West Bengal (Operation Barga) due to strong political mobilization of the rural poor. **[1 Mark]**

• **Reasons for Failure Elsewhere:** Landlords used political influence to delay legislation, divorced wives fictitiously, and carried out 'benami transfers' (transferring excess land to fictitious names or servants) to evade ceilings. **[1.5 Marks]**

**4. Evaluate the positive and negative socioeconomic impacts of the Green Revolution in India. [Score: 4 Marks]**

**Answer & Key Valuation Steps:**

• **Positive Impacts:** Massive increase in wheat and rice production, converting India from a food-deficit country reliant on PL-480 American food aid to a food-secure and grain-exporting nation. **[1.5 Marks]**

• **Social Disparities:** Wealthy farmers who could afford tube wells and tractors reaped huge profits, while marginal farmers who took loans for inputs fell into debt; increased regional disparity between irrigated and dry regions. **[1.5 Marks]**

• **Ecological Fallout:** Groundwater depletion through intensive tubewell drilling, soil salinization, and pesticide contamination of local water bodies. **[1 Mark]**

**5. What does Jan Breman mean by the term 'footloose labour'? Describe the working conditions of such seasonal agricultural workers. [Score: 4 Marks]**

**Answer & Key Valuation Steps:**

• **Concept:** A term coined by sociologist Jan Breman to describe landless rural labourers who are uprooted from their traditional villages and forced to constantly circulate between seasonal agricultural regions and urban informal sites. **[1.5 Marks]**

• **Working Conditions:** Recruited through exploitative middlemen (mukadams), paid below statutory minimum wages, worked for grueling hours, and subjected to debt bondage. **[1.5 Marks]**

• **Lack of Rights:** Deprived of local voting rights, social welfare schemes, clean drinking water, and safe shelter at destination sites. **[1 Mark]**

**6. Explain the phenomenon of the 'feminization of agricultural labour' in contemporary rural India. [Score: 4 Marks]**

**Answer & Key Valuation Steps:**

• **Definition:** The increasing proportion of women performing agricultural field labour relative to men in the rural countryside. **[1 Mark]**

• **Male Out-Migration:** Distress migration of rural men to towns and cities in search of non-farm construction or service jobs leaves women behind to cultivate family land and work as hired labourers. **[1.5 Marks]**

• **Disproportionate Burden and Low Wages:** Women perform backbreaking agricultural tasks (transplanting paddy, weeding) while receiving significantly lower wages than male workers and lacking formal legal title to land. **[1.5 Marks]**

**7. Analyze the major structural causes responsible for the recurring crisis of farmers' suicides in Indian agriculture. [Score: 4 Marks]**

**Answer & Key Valuation Steps:**

• **Shift to Commercial Cash Crops:** Transition from subsistence crops to high-risk cash crops (such as Bt cotton, soybean, sugarcane) requiring expensive chemical seeds and pesticides. **[1 Mark]**

• **Decline of State Subsidies and Price Volatility:** Post-liberalization reduction in farm input subsidies and removal of import protections, exposing farmers to volatile global market price crashes. **[1.5 Marks]**

• **Informal Usury and Ecological Shocks:** Collapse of institutional rural credit forces farmers into loans with local moneylenders at 36 to 60 percent annual interest; when pests or droughts strike, debt traps trigger suicides. **[1.5 Marks]**